

instead of executing a single program continuously until it was over, the computer executed chunks of different programs sequentially so that several programs (or users) were catered to simultaneously. To do this, a sort of logic was required on how programs would be stored and given to the CPU, how the results would be stored and retrieved for the next round of processing, which user or program had to be prioritised, and so on. This task was handled by separate pieces of software that, in a way, controlled how other programs were executed in a system. Later on, as a larger variety of hardware came into use, software was needed that would be an interface between the programs and the hardware. This need for interfacing applications and hardware, and controlling how applications were serviced, led to the development of the operating system.

So, what OS was being used in those early computers?

Well, it's not quite possible to make a list of operating systems of the earlier days as we can today. This is because there was no generic OS, and operating systems would be written specifically for each machine or purpose. Some notable OSes at that time were FORTRAN Monitor System, General Motors Operating System, Admiral, B-series, and Honeywell Executive System. There were many more besides these, owing to the variety of hardware that was being developed. But for our purposes, it is enough to say that the OSes at that time greatly helped improve the performance of those primitive machines.

One of the big initiatives undertaken to develop an OS at that time was the Multics project at MIT in 1965 by Bell Labs with



A Multics System at use